Hurricane KARINA

Hurricane LOWELL

Tropical Storm KROVANH

Hurricane MARIE

Global Tropics Outlook

Climate Prediction Center

Week 2 - Valid: Sep 09, 2026 - Sep 15, 2026

Week 3 - Valid: Sep 16, 2026 - Sep 22, 2026

Graphic provided by Climate Prediction Center

See my new article: *How I Met Hurricane Camille*

What Is a Hurricane?

A hurricane (or typhoon, or severe tropical cyclone), the strongest storm on Earth, is a cyclonic (rotary) storm that derives its energy from cloud formation and rainfall, unlike frontal cyclones that derive their power from a temperature gradient.

A hurricane begins as a tropical depression with a sustained wind speed of less than 39 mph (33 knots, 63 km/hr). As the system strengthens, it becomes a tropical storm with winds from 39 to 73 mph (33-63 knots, 63-118 km/hr). Tropical storms are named in the Atlantic, East, Central and Northwest Pacific, in the South Indian Ocean, and in the Arabian Sea. When the winds are sustained (based on a one-minute average) at 74 mph (64 knots, 119 km/hr), the storm becomes a hurricane in the East Pacific, Central Pacific (east of the International Dateline) and Southeast Pacific (east of 160°E) a **Hurricane**; in the Northwest Pacific (west of the International Dateline) a **Typhoon**; in the Southwest Pacific (west of 160°E) and Southeast Indian Ocean (east of 90°E) a **Severe Tropical Cyclone**; in the North Indian Ocean a **Severe Cyclonic Storm**; and in the Southwest Indian Ocean (west of 90°E) a **Tropical Cyclone**.

The Saffir-Simpson Hurricane Scale

Category 1 – 64-82 knots (74-95 mph; 119-153 km/h). Damage is limited to foliage, signage, unanchored boats and mobile homes. There is no significant damage to buildings. The main threat to life and property may be flooding from heavy rains.

Category 2 – 83-95 knots (96-110 mph; 154-177 km/h). Roof damage to buildings. Doors and windows damaged. Mobile homes severely damaged. Piers damaged by storm surge. Some trees blown down. Severe coastal erosion from storm surge.

Category 3 – 96-112 knots (111-129 mph; 178-208 km/h). Major Hurricane. Structural damage to some buildings. Mobile homes are completely destroyed. Roof damage is common. Storm surge begins to cause significant damage in beaches and harbors, with small buildings destroyed.

Category 4 – 113-136 knots (130-156 mph; 209-251 km/h). Structural failure of some buildings. Complete roof failures on many buildings. Extreme storm surge damage and flooding. Severe coastal erosion, with permanent changes to the coastal landscape not unheard of. Hurricane force winds carried inland.

Category 5 – 137+ knots (157+ mph; 252+ km/h). Complete roof failure on most buildings. Many buildings destroyed, or structurally damaged beyond repair. Catastrophic storm surge damage. In the Northwest Pacific, a typhoon that reaches 150 mph (241 km/hr) is called a Super Typhoon.

SAFFIR-SIMPSON SCALE

Category	Knots	MPH	KM/H	Damage
1	64-82	74-95	119-153	Minimal
2	83-95	96-110	154-177	Moderate
3	96-112	111-129	178-208	Extensive
4	113-136	130-156	209-251	Extreme
Super Typhoon	130+	241+		Catastrophic
5	137+	157+	252+	Catastrophic

Storm Surge

Historically, storm surge is the primary killer in hurricanes. The exact storm surge in any given area will be determined by how quickly the water depth increases offshore. In deep-water environments, such as the Hawaiian islands, storm surge will be enhanced by the rapidly decreasing ocean depth as the wind-driven surge approaches the coast. The peak storm surge is on the right-front quadrant (left-front in the Southern Hemisphere) of the eyewall as landfall, where onshore winds are the strongest, and at the leading edge of the eyewall. Contrary to a popular myth, the storm surge is entirely wind-driven water—it is not caused by the low pressure of the eye. Another factor in the severity of the storm surge is tide. Obviously, an 18-foot storm surge is worse if it hits that may occur than an 18-foot surge at low tide.

Tropical Cyclone Formation

By Jonathan Edwards

Tropical Cyclone Genesis is the technical term for the process of storm formation that leads ultimately to what are called hurricanes, typhoons, or tropical cyclones in various parts of the world.

This occurs when, in the Northern Hemisphere, the Intertropical Convergence Zone, or ITCZ, shifts northward out of the doldrums and atmospheric conditions become favorable for tropical cyclone formation after about the middle of May.

A series of low-pressure ripples develop in the ITCZ when the [Coriolis force](#) begins to act. The Coriolis force is zero at the equator, but increases, then typically shift their movement toward the west-southwest, or even northwest, after crossing 45° or 50° W longitude.

These tropical waves, ideally embedded in the deep-layer easterly flow, contain a northeast wind shift. This is typically referred to as a "coootrogene", where lines of equal atmospheric pressure are pressed together between the high-pressure ridge to the north and the developing low-pressure system. The pressure gradient ahead of the convergence zone produces a northeast wind at the axis of the tropical wave approaches. Gusts up to 25 mph may occur. Sometimes there can be gusts to tropical storm force in stronger waves. There can be surge in the weather associated with these waves, and they may pass virtually unnoticed. More typically, there are bands of disturbed weather riding the axis of the wave.

When the wave passes over warmer waters (SSTs), convection and resulting rainfall are enhanced. This greater rainfall is accompanied with falling surface pressures. By the time these pressures fall to 1008mb, it is likely that the northeast wind has closed off to a southwest wind on the backside of the wave. The forward motion of the wave completes the closure on the northern side of a broad low-level center, and a tropical depression has formed.

We often hear that a tropical depression has formed, but conditions are unfavorable for further development. There are two conditions to continue. The eyewall begins to make its appearance, usually on the [Image courtesy NOAA]

Eye formation begins when a tropical storm reaches approximately 65mph, provided conditions are favorable. Eye formation usually occurs first in the Northern Hemisphere side of the storm, and typically on the eastern (Northern Hemisphere) edge of the center. As the system becomes better organized and stronger, the center contracts from about 200 miles across to roughly 90 miles at this stage. An increase in rotational velocity accompanies the smaller, more defined center. The inflow is spiralling in ever faster as it is evacuated up through the developing eyewall and out by the high level outflow. The eyewall is the most dangerous part of the storm, with the strongest winds in the upper levels of the atmosphere, where high pressure that not only helps clear the eye, but can also produce a feature known as the "moat", which is an area of relatively weak convection outside the eye of the mature tropical cyclone. The combination of eye and moat can make the storm's core look like a doughnut. The eye can have a diameter anywhere from 10 to 40 miles across.

Tropical cyclones can exhibit a great deal of durability provided that the upper level support remains and the southerly (Northern Hemisphere), or tropical, inflow is present. Here are some examples. In 1998, Hurricane Mitch developed into a supermassive Category 5 hurricane. Nevertheless weakening began when the center moved to a position directly north of Honduras, cutting off the southerly inflow, and producing a "naked swirl" of broken cloud with embedded showers. Later, Mitch reintensified and regained all the characteristics of a mature hurricane except the small eye. Assuming all the ingredients are in place—warm SSTs, upper-level high pressure, and falling surface pressures—the cyclone will develop and reach a point of rapid intensification. It is one of nature's perfect machines. As warm waters feed the convection swirling around the center, heavy rainfall lowers surface pressures, high pressure aloft evacuates the inflow, which intensifies the inflow of warm, moist air, which in turn increases the rainfall and brings about a more rapid fall in central pressure.

Tropical cyclones have the low-level circulation and the upper-level circulation (outflow), whose formation was discussed above. There is also a mid-level circulation. The mid-level circulation is similar in structure to the low-level circulation, and is critical to the survival of a tropical cyclone that is passing over land. The lower-level circulation can be severely disrupted, or even dissipated, by interaction with land, especially mountainous terrain. However, if the mid-level circulation remains intact, the cyclone can regenerate rapidly when it reemerges over water, providing other factors are favorable.

Tropical cyclones can exhibit a great deal of durability provided that the upper level support remains and the southerly (Northern Hemisphere), or tropical, inflow is present. Here are some examples. In 1998, Hurricane Mitch developed into a supermassive Category 5 hurricane. Nevertheless weakening began when the center moved to a position directly north of Honduras, cutting off the southerly inflow, and producing a "naked swirl" of broken cloud with embedded showers. Later, Mitch reintensified and regained all the characteristics of a mature hurricane except the small eye. Assuming all the ingredients are in place—warm SSTs, upper-level high pressure, and falling surface pressures—the cyclone will develop and reach a point of rapid intensification. It is one of nature's perfect machines. As warm waters feed the convection swirling around the center, heavy rainfall lowers surface pressures, high pressure aloft evacuates the inflow, which intensifies the inflow of warm, moist air, which in turn increases the rainfall and brings about a more rapid fall in central pressure.

Tropical cyclones have the low-level circulation and the upper-level circulation (outflow), whose formation was discussed above. There is also a mid-level circulation. The mid-level circulation is similar in structure to the low-level circulation, and is critical to the survival of a tropical cyclone that is passing over land. The lower-level circulation can be severely disrupted, or even dissipated, by interaction with land, especially mountainous terrain. However, if the mid-level circulation remains intact, the cyclone can regenerate rapidly when it reemerges over water, providing other factors are favorable.

COPYRIGHT CLIVE LORD, STORMDOM GRAPHICS. ALL RIGHTS RESERVED. PERMISSION IS GRANTED TO REPRODUCE THE IMAGES, TEXT AND ARTWORK ON THIS PAGE FOR NON-COMMERCIAL PURPOSES ONLY, INCLUDING BY FORMATS OF DISPLAY MEDIA, IF YOU DO SO YOU MUST CLEARLY AND PROMINENTLY ATTRIBUTE THE PRIOR WRITTEN CONSENT OF JONATHAN EDWARDS. THE STORMDOM BANNER AND THE WORDS "GLOBAL STORM TRACKER" ARE A TRADE MARK OF JONATHAN EDWARDS. JONATHAN EDWARDS SHALL NOT BE LIABLE FOR ANY DAMAGES ARISING FROM THE USE OF THIS PAGE OR ITS CONTENTS.

After landfall. Tropical cyclones cannot survive over land, over their access to warm SST is removed. A powerful hurricane, such as Hugo, which hit Charleston, S.C., in 1989 can persist like-threatening hurricane force winds over two hundred miles inland. As the storm progresses inland, it can dump a huge amount of rain—sometimes measured in feet. The storm may evolve into a tropical cyclone that continues to cause widespread damage. A classic example of this is Hurricane Camille in 1969—the strongest hurricane ever to make landfall on the continental United States with winds sustained at 190 mph and gusts well exceeding 200 mph—which reared up the Mississippi Valley and eventually exited off the East Coast. Camille maintained tropical storm strength as far as Memphis, Tennessee. Most hurricanes will diminish in strength rapidly after landfall, reaching tropical depression strength by 48 to 72 hours. The main threat from the dying storm is from tornadoes and torrential flooding. The final landfall candidate of a hurricane or typhoon in the Northern Hemisphere is usually the Southeast United States or most frequently the wing side of the storm. This is because the forward motion is added to the counter-clockwise punch of the storm. Thus, the right-hand side of the hurricane contains the strong on-shore flow. This is where the maximum storm surge flooding, and the greatest potential loss of life, will be experienced. After landfall, the circulation's motion over land causes a great deal of turbulence, which results in weakening. Typical cyclones cannot survive over land, over their access to warm SST is removed.

Upwelling. When a hurricane stalls, its movement is has fallen below 5mph, or its movement is erratic over a small area, the wave action caused by the strong surface winds churns the ocean surface and produces upwelling. This has the effect of cooling the temperature of the sea surface over an area 200 to 300 miles across. The result is weakening. It is possible for a hurricane to stall in one area long enough that it dissipates. In 2004, Hurricane Frances stalled off the southeast Florida coast long enough that the core of the hurricane collapsed. Frances eventually made landfall as a Category 1 hurricane, instead of the earlier expected Category 3.

Entraining dry air. Sometimes, during the peak season, when tropical cyclones approach continental land masses, they may entrain dry air as part of their interaction with frontal troughs that carry cool, dry air behind them. The dry air kills off the convection that drive the hurricane's engine. If the dry air crosses the storm's core, the storm will weaken.

Moving over cool water. Similar to upwelling, when a tropical cyclone moves over cool water (below 77° Fahrenheit/25° Celsius), it begins to weaken. Eventually this causes dissipation, particularly in the East Pacific. In the Atlantic, if the storm is caught in the mid-latitude westerlies and begins to recurve to the northeast, it generally becomes an extratropical storm the first time it has crossed 40° to 45° N. This is the so-called "graveyard" of Atlantic hurricanes. The storm becomes extratropical when it has transitioned to a cold-core, baroclinically driven system, and eventually becomes a gale in the north Atlantic, or is absorbed by a large gale. This is where the Atlantic ocean's upper-level support structure. Poleward outflow is restricted. A hurricane can still maintain itself when outflow is restricted in one quadrant. It outflow becomes too restricted, resulting shear can disrupted the inner core.

Exposure to upper-level westerlies. Frequently, the ridge of high pressure that keeps the hurricane heading toward the west erodes. In the Atlantic Ocean, this may result in strong upper-level winds blowing down and impinging on the hurricane's upper-level support structure. Poleward outflow is restricted. A hurricane can still maintain itself when outflow is restricted in one quadrant. It outflow becomes too restricted, resulting shear can disrupted the inner core.

Weakening. Tropical cyclones cannot survive over land, over their access to warm SST is removed. A powerful hurricane, such as Hugo, which hit Charleston, S.C., in 1989 can persist like-threatening hurricane force winds over two hundred miles inland. As the storm progresses inland, it can dump a huge amount of rain—sometimes measured in feet. The storm may evolve into a tropical cyclone that continues to cause widespread damage. A classic example of this is Hurricane Camille in 1969—the strongest hurricane ever to make landfall on the continental United States with winds sustained at 190 mph and gusts well exceeding 200 mph—which reared up the Mississippi Valley and eventually exited off the East Coast. Camille maintained tropical storm strength as far as Memphis, Tennessee. Most hurricanes will diminish in strength rapidly after landfall, reaching tropical depression strength by 48 to 72 hours. The main threat from the dying storm is from tornadoes and torrential flooding. The final landfall candidate of a hurricane or typhoon in the Northern Hemisphere is usually the Southeast United States or most frequently the wing side of the storm. This is because the forward motion is added to the counter-clockwise punch of the storm. Thus, the right-hand side of the hurricane contains the strong on-shore flow. This is where the maximum storm surge flooding, and the greatest potential loss of life, will be experienced. After landfall, the circulation's motion over land causes a great deal of turbulence, which results in weakening. Typical cyclones cannot survive over land, over their access to warm SST is removed.